# CROSS AND CURRENTS

**The BJP fields Congress leader A.K. Antony's son in the Pathanamthitta LS seat. Can he upset the status quo, help the lotus bloom in central Kerala?**

By Jeemon Jacob




Former defence minister and Congress leader A.K. Antony has always maintained a spotless, carefully cultivated image in his seven-decade-long sojourn through democracy's pathways. But at the ripe old age of 84, the man once described as the St. Antony of Indian politics finds himself at a political crossroads. Elder son Anil Antony has defected to the BJP and is making his electoral debut in the Pathanamthitta Lok Sabha seat in south Kerala against one of his father's staunch followers, sitting Congress MP Anto Antony. CPI(M) leader and former state finance minister Dr Thomas Isaac is the third face in the contest. All the buzz in the constituency is whether Antony Sr will campaign in Pathanamthitta or not.

The veteran leader has not been keeping well, but on March 26 he made sure to let the press know where his loyalties lay. He said it is a "do or die battle" for the Congress and the country to save democracy. There is pressure on him to campaign in Pathanamthitta, especially after Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed a BJP poll rally on March 19, pitching for Anil.

The Pathanamthitta LS constituency has only ever elected Congress candidates and 66-year old Anto is looking to make this a fourth consecutive triumph. This election is different, for all three big candidates in the fray are Catholics. Though the denomination has limited presence in the region, Christians do make up over 38 per cent of the voters and Muslims about 6 per cent. But religion has not been a big factor so far in elections. Indeed, an inside joke is that rubber prices (plantations small and big are a common sight here) and NRIs (a disproportionate part of the population) decide the winning combination in the constituency.

**THE BJP HAS MADE AN OUTREACH TO CHURCH LEADERS TO WIN OVER LOCAL CHRISTIANS. BUT A.K. ANTONY HASN'T YET ENDORSED HIS SON**

BJP sources say before fielding the 38-year-old Anil, the central leadership had analysed the poll profile of the constituency and found that an upset is possible if a section of the Christian community backs the candidate. The party has apparently made tactical agreements with the Syrian Orthodox and Marthoma churches for their support. The Believers Eastern Church, an oriental Pentecostal church, is also allegedly onboard. The cash-rich church was raided by IT officials in 2020 for violating the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act. Since then, they have been quite accommodating—the Kerala government is constructing the Sabarimala airport on 2,262 acres of land acquired from the church.

PM Modi's endorsement has given Anil's campaign a much-needed boost. Veteran marketing professional G. Chandran, who is handling the candidate's media operations, says, "Within a short time, Anil has managed to attract big crowds. We have designed the campaign pitching him as a national leader. If he wins, he is going to be a Union minister." According to Chandran, the BJP considers the Congress candidate the main threat